Moving to Denver: A Relocation Guide

Which neighborhoods fit which lifestyles, what it really costs to live here, how schools work, and everything to handle in your first 90 days. Written by someone who grew up in Colorado.



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Where to Live in Denver

Most people moving here start by asking which neighborhood is "best." The better question is how you want to live day to day. Here's where I'd start, depending on what matters most to you.

If You Want	Start With	Why
A park at the end of the street	Washington Park, Bonnie Brae	Classic homes, mature trees and Denver's most loved park.
To walk to dinner	Platt Park, Capitol Hill	South Pearl Street, or nearly everything within a few blocks.
A newer home in the city	Cory-Merrill, Sloan Lake	More new construction than most central neighborhoods.
Space and suburban schools	Greenwood Village, Belcaro	Bigger lots, quiet streets, short commutes to the Tech Center.
An easy airport run	South Park Hill	Grand parkways on the east side, closest to the airport.
A first condo or townhome	Capitol Hill	The widest choice of condos, in walkable historic buildings.

Compare all nine side by side on the neighborhood guides page.

Cost of Living and Taxes

Denver costs more than the national average, mostly because of housing. Taxes are moderate, and property taxes are low compared with many states.

4.4%	9.15%	$1.45M	$295K
flat Colorado state income tax	combined sales tax in the City of Denver	median single-family sale in Washington Park	median condo or townhome sale in Capitol Hill

Income tax: Tax Foundation. Sales tax: Avalara, 2026 rates. Home prices: REcolorado closed sales, November 2025 to October 2026.

- **Income tax.** Colorado has a single flat rate of 4.4% on taxable income. There's no separate city income tax for most residents, though Denver charges a small monthly occupational privilege tax to people who work in the city.
- **Sales tax.** In the City of Denver it adds up to 9.15%: 2.9% state, 5.15% city, 1% for RTD transit and 0.1% for the region's arts and science district. Rates differ in the suburbs.
- **Property taxes.** Colorado's rates are low by national standards, and they're paid a year behind. Your exact bill depends on the assessed value and the mill levies where you live.
- **Home insurance.** Plan for higher premiums than in many states. Front Range hail is the reason, and insurers look closely at roof age and condition.

Want to see what a specific home would cost each month? Try the monthly payment calculator.

Schools

How you enroll depends on the district, and that depends on the address.

Denver Public Schools and SchoolChoice

Denver Public Schools uses an application system called SchoolChoice. Families rank the schools they want, and DPS matches students to schools by lottery and priorities. In some parts of the city, an enrollment zone guarantees a seat at one of several nearby schools rather than a single neighborhood school.

- **Round 1** usually opens in January and closes in February for the following school year, with results in March.

- **Round 2** runs from spring through late August on a first-come, first-served basis, and it's open to families who are new to DPS.
- You'll need proof of a Denver address to enroll, so time your purchase or lease with the school calendar in mind.

Suburban Districts

Suburban districts like Cherry Creek, which serves most of Greenwood Village, generally assign students by address. Always confirm the assigned school for a specific home with the district before you buy, because boundaries can split neighborhoods.

Getting Around

- **The airport.** Denver International Airport sits well east of the city. The A Line commuter train runs from Union Station downtown to the airport, and the east-side neighborhoods have the shortest drive.
- **Light rail.** RTD light rail runs along I-25 through south Denver to the Tech Center, with stations near Platt Park, Washington Park and Greenwood Village.
- **Driving.** I-25 runs north and south through the city, and I-70 heads west to the mountains. Most central neighborhoods are within 15 minutes of downtown outside rush hour.
- **Biking.** The Cherry Creek Trail and South Platte River Trail connect much of the city, and neighborhoods like Wash Park and Platt Park are easy to get around by bike.

Altitude and Weather

Denver sits at 5,280 feet, one mile above sea level. Most people adjust within a few days. Drink more water than you think you need, go easy on alcohol at first, and wear sunscreen, because the sun is stronger up here.

The weather surprises most newcomers in a good way. Winters are sunnier and milder than people expect, and snow in the city usually melts within a few days. Spring brings wet snow and hailstorms, summer afternoons often bring short thunderstorms, and fall is long and dry.

“I grew up in Breckenridge, so the mountains are home for me. My best advice for newcomers: leave early for the ski areas, and plan your mountain weekends around I-70 traffic, not the other way around.”



Chris Nowakiwsky, Broker Associate

New Resident Checklist

The first few weeks in a new home go smoother with these handled early.

1 **Set Up Utilities**

Before move-in

Xcel Energy provides electricity and natural gas across most of the metro, and Denver Water serves the city. Your title company or seller can confirm providers for a specific home.

2 **Enroll the Kids**

As soon as you have an address

Apply through DPS SchoolChoice or your suburban district with proof of address.

3 **Get a Colorado Driver's License**

Within 30 days of residency

Transfer your out-of-state license at a Colorado DMV office. Book an appointment ahead of time.

4 **Register to Vote**

After you move

Colorado lets you register online, and every registered voter is mailed a ballot.

5 **Test for Radon**

Any time

Radon levels are high across much of Colorado. A simple test kit tells you whether a home needs mitigation.

Driver's license deadline: Colorado DMV, New to Colorado.

Buying From Out of State

Most relocating buyers can't fly in every weekend. Here's how we can make the search work from wherever you are now:

- **Narrow it down first.** We start with a video call about how you want to live, then pick two or three neighborhoods to focus on.
- **Live video tours.** I'll walk homes with you on FaceTime or Zoom and point out what photos hide: street noise, the neighbor's yard, the condition of the alley.
- **One focused trip.** When you do fly in, we tour a short list of homes you've already vetted, and you can often write an offer before you fly home.
- **Remote closing.** Much of the paperwork can be signed electronically, and the title company can arrange a mobile notary for the rest.

> *"We truly could not have asked for a better experience."*
>
> A family who relocated to Colorado with Chris · Zillow review

Relocation FAQ

Is Denver a Good Place to Live?

For people who love the outdoors, sunshine and an active city with the mountains an hour away, it's one of the most appealing places in the country. The trade-offs are housing costs above the national average, traffic to the mountains on weekends, and the adjustment to altitude and dry air.

What Are the Best Neighborhoods for Families Moving to Denver?

Families often start with Washington Park, Bonnie Brae, Cory-Merrill and South Park Hill for their parks and neighborhood feel, or Greenwood Village for larger lots and Cherry Creek schools. The right fit depends on your budget, commute and the specific schools assigned to an address.

What Is the Sales Tax in Denver?

The combined sales tax in the City of Denver is 9.15% in 2026: 2.9% state, 5.15% city, 1% for RTD and 0.1% for the Scientific and Cultural Facilities District. Rates differ in suburban cities.

What Is Colorado's State Income Tax Rate?

Colorado has a flat income tax of 4.4% on taxable income. Most Denver residents don't pay a separate city income tax, though people who work in Denver pay a small monthly occupational privilege tax.

How Long Do I Have to Get a Colorado Driver's License?

New residents have 30 days after establishing Colorado residency to get a Colorado driver's license. Book a DMV appointment ahead of time, since slots fill up.

Does It Snow a Lot in Denver?

Denver gets real snowstorms, especially in spring, but the city is sunnier and milder than most people expect. Snow on the streets usually melts within a few days. The deep snow is in the mountains, about an hour or two west.

How Does School Enrollment Work in Denver?

Denver Public Schools uses SchoolChoice, where families rank schools and are matched by lottery and priorities. Round 1 usually runs January to February for the next school year, and Round 2 runs through late August for families who are new to DPS. Suburban districts generally assign schools by address.

Questions? Let's Talk.

Every move is different. If you'd like to talk through your plans, your neighborhood or your numbers, I'm happy to help, with no pressure and no obligation.



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